

SERENE SPLENDOUR

Assam, with its natural beauty, rich cultural heritage, and diverse wildlife, is emerging as a prime tourism destination, supported by government initiatives like industry status and promotion of homestays and tea tourism. The roadmap is to attract investment, enhance visitor experiences, and stimulate economic growth through sustainable tourism practices.

■ By a special correspondent ■

Assam is a treasure trove of natural beauty, rich cultural heritage, and diverse wildlife, making it a burgeoning hub for tourism. Known for its picturesque landscapes, the northeastern state boasts the mighty Brahmaputra River, lush tea gardens, and the pristine hills of the Eastern Himalayas. The state's rich biodiversity is showcased in its numerous national parks and wildlife sanctuaries, including Kaziranga National Park, a UNESCO World Heritage site, and Manas National Park, both famous for their populations of the Indian one-horned rhinoceros and other rare species. Assam's cultural vibrancy is evident in its festivals including Bihu, celebrated by everyone irrespective of caste, creed and beliefs, and the state's rich traditions of handloom and handicrafts, which draw in both domestic and international tourists.

In recent years, the Assam government has taken significant steps to boost tourism and make the state a more attractive destination for travellers. A significant move by the Assam government to boost tourism has been granting industry status to the tourism sector. This landmark decision is expected to attract more investment into the sector by providing various incentives and benefits typically available to industries. These incentives include subsidies, tax concessions, and simplified regulatory procedures, which will make it easier for businesses to invest in and develop tourism-related infrastructure and services. By recognizing tourism as an industry, the government aims to stimulate growth, create employment opportunities, and enhance the overall economic development of the state.

Another major initiative is the development of tourism infrastructure, including improved road connectivity, better accommodation facilities, and the modernization of tourist sites. The government has also focused on promoting eco-tourism and rural tourism, which aim to provide a sustainable and authentic experience for

103% Growth in the footfall of domestic tourists in Assam in 2023

523% Growth in the footfall of international tourists in Assam in 2023

3,27,493 Total number of tourists visiting Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve in 2023-24, the highest since the establishment of the national park. Of these, 3,13,574 are Indian tourists and 13,919 are international visitors.